

Rembrandt

Ranking among the greatest artists of all time, painter, draughtsman and etcher Rembrandt Harmenszoon van Rijn (1606–69) transformed his subjects with technical mastery. His dramatically lit scenes display action, drama or disarming simplicity, and despite personal tragedies, his work never suffered.

At the age of 25, Rembrandt moved to Amsterdam from Leiden, where his dramatic chiaroscuro and atmospheric effects drew attention, and he was soon the city's leading portrait painter. After both his wife and mother died, he painted more mysterious, religious works. Nevertheless, his teaching skills were renowned and pupils flocked to join his studio. One of the first artists to paint directional brushstrokes, following the directions of objects being painted, his later works were captured in even broader marks, often applied with a palette knife. In the 1650s, a huge economic depression forced Rembrandt into a form of bankruptcy. He spent his final 20 years painting commissioned portraits and self-portraits that document the ageing process.



Rembrandt, *Self-Portrait with Two Circles*, c.1659–60